THE BATTLE OF RED CLIFFS

The Battle of the Red Cliffs, or Chibi as it is sometimes known, was a crucial point in the transition from the Han Dynasty to the Three Kingdoms period in Chinese history. The all-powerful Han minister Cao Cao had embarked on a campaign to unify China under his rule. His army was enormous and initially victorious. But in order to conquer southern China, he needed to gain command of the Yangtze River. This ambition was opposed by the warlords Liu Bei and Sun Quan, who formed an alliance to resist Cao Cao.

FIGHT OR SURRENDER

The warlords looked doomed when Cao captured a powerful river fleet and the Yangtze naval port of Jiangling. Cao loaded his men onto the boats and set off downstream toward Sun's power base at Chaisang. The majority of Sun's advisers advocated surrender, but his military commander Zhou Yu argued that Cao's forces were less formidable than they seemed. Exhausted after a long, hard campaign and unaccustomed to naval warfare, they would be outfought by a fresher enemy skilled in river fighting. What is more, he anticipated correctly that Cao's northeners would succumb to illness when they were exposed to the disease environment of the south.



Cao Cao on the eve of Red Cliffs
In this atmospheric 14th-century painting, the great general ponders the wisdom of confronting his enemies in a river battle.

Zhou Yu led the combined forces of Sun and Liu upriver. The precise location of their encounter with Cao's fleet is uncertain. The battle opened with indecisive skirmishing, after which the two sides broke off to rest. Cao was concerned about the spread of disease in his army and the difficulty his soldiers experienced in fighting on water. To provide a more stable platform for his troops, he had his boats lashed together in large groups. This made it impossible for them to maneuver and vulnerable to incendiary weapons, such as fire arrows, that were a feature of Chinese warfare.

It appears that a veteran soldier, Huang Gai, offered to sail fire ships, loaded with dry reeds and inflammable wax, into Cao's tethered fleet. To confuse the enemy, Huang approached Cao's boats pretending he wanted to surrender. Then the crews set the ships on fire, disembarked into small boats, and watched as the blazing vessels drifted down on to their immobile target.



FALL OF THE HAN DYNASTY

THE BATTLE OF RED CLIFFS

Date	208 CE
Location	Chibi, Yangtze River
Result	Victory for Liu Bei and Sun Quan

COMBATANTS

LIU BEI, SUN QUAN	CAO CAO

COMMANDERS

Zhou Yu	Cao Cao

FORCES

Men: c.50,000	**Men:** c.220,000

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** unknown	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** unknown

Enough of Cao's fleet was destroyed to discourage him from any further naval adventures. His army set off overland on a retreat that turned into a rout. The defeat ended Cao's chances of unifying China, which entered a period of warfare between conflicting kingdoms.



Unleashing the fire ships
Having ignited the flammable materials aboard the fire ships, Huang Gai's men escape in rowing boats as the ships drift downriver to collide with their targets.